Chapter 39 — Global App State Management

> **Part V — Shared & Global State** · Complexity: **Standard** (≥25 interview questions)
>
> **Prerequisites:** Ch 3 (SSOT), Ch 6 (UI state/UDF), Ch 22 (session state), Ch 38 (shared cart), Ch 5 (Hilt scoping). This chapter generalizes Ch 38's shared-state lesson to **app-wide** state and draws the line between global and feature state.
>
> **Reference surface in StreamCart:** session/auth state (Ch 22), connectivity (Ch 68), theme (Ch 4/97), feature flags (Ch 41), unread-notification count, and the current profile — state that *many* features read.

39.1 Problem Definition and Real-World Context

Some state belongs to a single screen, some to a feature (the cart, Ch 38), and a little is genuinely **global** — read by many unrelated features: who's logged in (Ch 22), whether the device is online (Ch 68), the theme, active feature flags (Ch 41), the unread-notification badge, the selected profile. Managing this app-wide state badly is a classic source of bugs and bad architecture:

- **The god object.** A single `AppState` / `GlobalStore` holding *everything* becomes a dumping ground — every feature depends on it, it's impossible to test, and a change anywhere ripples everywhere. The opposite of modular.
- **Scattered duplication.** Without a clear owner, five features each track "is logged in" or "is online" differently → inconsistency (one screen thinks you're offline, another doesn't).
- **Wrong scope / leaks.** Holding global state in an Activity/ViewModel loses it on process death or leaks the Activity; holding UI-local state globally bloats memory and couples features.
- **Over-globalization.** Treating feature state (the cart) as "global" couples unrelated code; treating truly-global state (session) as feature-local causes divergence. Knowing *what is actually global* is the real skill.

The architecture: expose each piece of global state through a **small, focused, app-scoped holder** (a repository/manager exposing a `StateFlow`), **owned by one module**, observed by whoever needs it — **not** one monolithic store. Draw a clear boundary: **global** (session, connectivity, theme, flags) vs **feature** (cart, Ch 38) vs **screen** (UI state, Ch 6). This chapter is about **identifying, owning, exposing, and scoping** global state without a god object.

Three practical use cases

1. **Session/auth (StreamCart).** `SessionManager` (Ch 22) exposes `SessionState`; the nav root, interceptors, and features all read it — one global source.
2. **Connectivity (all).** A `ConnectivityManager` holder (Ch 68) exposes online/offline; many features show offline banners from the same signal.
3. **Theme / unread count / flags.** Small focused holders (DataStore-backed theme, Ch 4; a notifications badge count; `FeatureFlags`, Ch 41) each owned and observed app-wide.

Why this is architectural

Global state management defines **what is truly app-wide**, **who owns each piece**, **how it's exposed and observed**, and **how to avoid a monolithic store** — the properties that keep cross-cutting state consistent without coupling the whole app.

39.2 Requirements Engineering

Functional requirements

ID	Requirement
F1	Identify genuinely global state (read by many features) vs feature/screen state.
F2	Each global state has a single owner (app-scoped holder) exposing a `StateFlow`.
F3	Any feature can observe global state reactively; one source of truth each.
F4	Global state survives navigation/config change; durable where needed (Ch 4).
F5	Avoid a single god object; keep holders small and focused.
F6	Global state is cleared/reset appropriately (logout, Ch 22).

Non-functional requirements

Attribute	Policy
Consistency	One owner per global state; no duplication/divergence.
Modularity	Features depend on narrow holders, not a monolith.
Testability	Holders injectable/fakeable; no static singletons.
Lifecycle	App-scoped; survives nav/config; durable via Ch 4 where needed.
Memory	Only truly-global state is global; no UI state bloat.

Scope

- **In scope:** what counts as global, app-scoped state holders (repository/manager + `StateFlow`), exposing/observing, scoping via Hilt, avoiding the god object, reset/clear, composing multiple global states.
- **Out of scope:** feature-shared state (cart, Ch 38), screen UI state (Ch 6), shared ViewModel scoping (Ch 40), the specific holders' internals (session Ch 22, connectivity Ch 68, flags Ch 41, theme Ch 97).

Assumptions & constraints

- Hilt (`@Singleton` holders), `StateFlow`, DataStore (durable global config, Ch 4). `minSdk 24`. "Global" = app-scoped (survives navigation/config), **not** a static object.

39.3 System Design Fundamentals

- **What is "global" state?** State read by **many unrelated features** and tied to the app/user session, not a single feature or screen: session/auth (Ch 22), connectivity (Ch 68), theme (Ch 97), feature flags (Ch 41), current profile, app-wide counters (unread). If only one feature uses it, it's **feature state** (own it there); if only one screen, it's **UI state** (Ch 6). **Resist making things global** — globalization couples code.
- **One focused holder per global state (not a god object).** Each global state gets a small, app-scoped (`@Singleton`) **holder** (a repository/manager) that owns it and exposes a read-only `StateFlow` (+ methods to change it). Many small holders > one monolith: focused dependencies, testable in isolation, independent evolution.
- **App-scoped, not static.** "Global" means **application lifetime via DI** (`@Singleton` in `SingletonComponent`, Ch 5) — injectable and fakeable — **not** a Kotlin `object` singleton (untestable, leak-prone) or Activity-held state (lost on process death).
- **Expose as state, consume via UDF.** Holders expose `StateFlow<T>`; features `combine`/observe them into their own `UiState` (Ch 6). Global state flows down; changes go through the holder's methods — the same UDF discipline, app-wide.
- **Durability where needed.** Global state that must survive process death is backed by a store: **DataStore** for config (theme, flags — Ch 4), **Room** for data (session derived from token presence, Ch 22). In-memory-only global state (connectivity) is recomputed on start.
- **Composition over a central store.** When a feature needs several global states, it **combines** the relevant holders (`combine(session, connectivity, flags)`) — no central store mediates; features depend only on what they use.
- **Reset/clear.** Global state is reset on lifecycle events: logout clears session- scoped global state (Ch 22/42); theme/flags persist (device-scoped).

Core insight: **expose each genuinely-global state through its own small, app-scoped, injectable holder with a `StateFlow`, owned by one module and observed via UDF — never a monolithic god object, and never more "global" than it needs to be.**

39.4 High-Level Architecture


39.4 High-Level Architecture

Components & ownership

- **Each global state** = one focused `@Singleton` holder exposing a `StateFlow`.
- **Features** observe only the holders they need (narrow dependencies).
- **DataStore/Room** back durable global state (Ch 4/22).
- **No central god object** mediating everything.

Direction: holder owns + exposes `StateFlow`; features observe (combine) what they need; changes go through holder methods.

39.5 Detailed Component Design



Global state	Holder	Backing	Scope
session/auth	`SessionManager` (Ch 22)	token presence (Room, Ch 20)	app, session-scoped
connectivity	`ConnectivityManager` (Ch 68)	OS callback	app, in-memory
theme	`ThemeRepository` (Ch 4/97)	DataStore	app, durable, device
feature flags	`FeatureFlags` (Ch 41)	DataStore + remote	app, durable
unread count	`UnreadCounter`	Room/remote	app, session-scoped

> **Test for "global":** if ≥2 unrelated features read it and it's tied to the app/ session, make it a focused `@Singleton` holder. Otherwise keep it in the feature (Ch 38) or the screen (Ch 6).

39.6 End-to-End Data Flow

A feature composing several global states



Global state change propagates app-wide



39.7 Complete Kotlin Implementation

Package: `com.streamcart.core.global` and per-concern modules.

39.7.1 A focused global holder (connectivity, Ch 68)

```
@Singleton
class ConnectivityManager @Inject constructor(
    @ApplicationContext context: Context,
    @ApplicationScope scope: CoroutineScope,
) {
    // Owns ONE global state; exposes read-only StateFlow.
    val state: StateFlow<NetworkState> = callbackFlow {
        val cm = context.getSystemService(android.net.ConnectivityManager::class.java)
        val cb = object : android.net.ConnectivityManager.NetworkCallback() {
            override fun onAvailable(n: Network) { trySend(NetworkState.Online) }
            override fun onLost(n: Network) { trySend(NetworkState.Offline) }
        }
        cm.registerDefaultNetworkCallback(cb)
        awaitClose { cm.unregisterNetworkCallback(cb) }
    }.stateIn(scope, SharingStarted.WhileSubscribed(5_000), NetworkState.Unknown)
}
```

39.7.2 A durable global holder (theme, Ch 4/97)

```
@Singleton
class ThemeRepository @Inject constructor(
    private val store: DataStore<Preferences>,          // durable (Ch 4)
    @ApplicationScope scope: CoroutineScope,
) {
    private val key = stringPreferencesKey("theme")
    val theme: StateFlow<Theme> = store.data
        .map { Theme.valueOf(it[key] ?: Theme.System.name) }
        .stateIn(scope, SharingStarted.Eagerly, Theme.System)   // app-wide, survives restart
    suspend fun setTheme(t: Theme) = store.edit { it[key] = t.name }.let {}
}
```

39.7.3 Features observe ONLY what they need (no god object)

```
@HiltViewModel
class ShopViewModel @Inject constructor(
    flags: FeatureFlags,                                  // Ch 41
    connectivity: ConnectivityManager,                   // Ch 68
    session: SessionManager,                              // Ch 22
    private val getProducts: GetProductsUseCase,
) : ViewModel() {
    // Compose the relevant global states into this screen's UiState (UDF, Ch 6).
    val uiState: StateFlow<ShopUiState> = combine(
        flags.observe("new_search"), connectivity.state, session.sessionState, getProducts(),
    ) { newSearch, net, sess, products ->
        ShopUiState(products, offline = net is NetworkState.Offline,
            showNewSearch = newSearch, loggedIn = sess is SessionState.Authenticated)
    }.stateIn(viewModelScope, SharingStarted.WhileSubscribed(5_000), ShopUiState.Loading)
}
// Settings injects only ThemeRepository; the top bar injects UnreadCounter + SessionManager.
Narrow deps.
```

39.7.4 Anti-pattern (what NOT to do)

```
// ANTI-PATTERN: a god object holding everything -> every feature depends on all of it.
// @Singleton class GlobalStore(val session, val cart, val theme, val flags, val unread, ...) {
val everything: StateFlow<AppState> }
// Instead: many small focused holders; features inject only what they use.
```

39.7.5 Reset on logout (session-scoped global state, Ch 22)

```
// SessionManager.logout() (Ch 22) resets session-scoped global holders:
// unread counter -> 0, profile -> null, etc. Device-scoped (theme) persists.
```

39.7.6 Module structure

```
:core:connectivity  ConnectivityManager (Ch 68)
:core:session       SessionManager (Ch 22)
:core:theme         ThemeRepository (Ch 4/97)
:core:flags         FeatureFlags (Ch 41)
# Each a focused @Singleton holder; features depend on the ones they use.
```

39.8 Concurrency and Race Conditions

Scenario	Risk	Handling
Multiple observers of a holder	duplicate work	`StateFlow` shares one value; `WhileSubscribed` / `Eagerly`
Concurrent updates to a holder	torn state	update through holder methods; `StateFlow` serializes; DataStore atomic (Ch 4)
Two features combine same holders	redundant collection	`StateFlow` is hot/shared; conflated
Global state change mid-navigation	inconsistent UI	all observers see the same conflated `StateFlow`
Reset during observation	stale value	reset sets a new value; observers re-render
Static singleton (anti)	leaks/untestable	use DI `@Singleton`, not Kotlin `object`

- **`StateFlow` + app-scoped holder makes global state inherently consistent:** every observer reads the same conflated value; there's no second copy to diverge.
- **All mutations go through the holder** (its methods), preserving UDF and a single writer — no feature mutates another's global state directly.

39.9 Failure Scenarios and Recovery

Failure	Detection	Response	Outcome
God object coupling	hard-to-test/change	split into focused holders	modular
Divergent "is online"/"logged in"	inconsistent UI	one holder; all observe it	consistent
Global state lost on process death	missing after restart	back with DataStore/Room (Ch 4/22)	durable
Over-globalized feature state	coupling	move to feature (Ch 38)	decoupled
Static singleton leak	LeakCanary (Ch 89)	DI `@Singleton`	no leak
Stale global state (flags)	not refreshed	holder refreshes (remote config, Ch 41)	fresh
Not reset on logout	cross-user leak	reset session-scoped holders (Ch 22)	clean


39.9 Failure Scenarios and Recovery

> **The decision tree is the chapter:** most state is *not* global. Make something global only when many unrelated features genuinely read it — and even then, a focused holder, never a god object.

39.10 Scaling the Implementation

- **Level 1.** A couple of `@Singleton` holders (session, connectivity) exposing `StateFlow`.

- **Level 2.** Durable global config (theme/flags via DataStore, Ch 4/41); features combine what they need.
- **Level 3 — production.** Clear global/feature/screen boundaries; reset-on-logout; focused holders per concern; no god object.
- **Level 4 — large.** Modularized global holders in `:core:*` modules; multi-module features depend only on needed holders; remote-config-driven global state (Ch 41).
- **Level 5 — enterprise.** Governed global-state taxonomy, per-module ownership, state observability, consistent reset/lifecycle policy across teams.

Avoid overengineering: don't build a "state management framework." A few focused `@Singleton` holders exposing `StateFlow` is the whole solution; adding Redux-style central stores to Android usually adds ceremony without benefit (the SSOT + UDF model already handles it).

39.11 Alternative Approaches and Trade-offs

Dimension	Option A	Option B	When
Structure	Many focused holders	single central store (Redux-like)	Focused holders fit Android (modular, testable); central store couples + adds ceremony
Scope	DI `@Singleton` (app)	Kotlin `object` singleton	DI always (testable, no leak); `object` for pure stateless utils only
Expose	`StateFlow` (read-only)	public mutable state	Read-only `StateFlow` + methods — enforce single writer
Durability	DataStore/Room backing	in-memory only	Back durable global state; in-memory for recomputable (connectivity)
Consumption	Feature combines needed holders	inject a monolith	Combine narrow deps — don't depend on everything
What's global	Only cross-cutting	"everything in a store"	Minimize global — most state is feature/screen

Focused holders vs a central store: web ecosystems popularized a single global store (Redux). On Android, the **SSOT + UDF + DI** model already provides reactive, testable state; a central store re-introduces global coupling, boilerplate, and a single point of change. Prefer **many small `@Singleton` holders** each owning one global state — features depend only on what they use. Use a "store"-like structure only if a team genuinely needs centralized time-travel/debugging and accepts the coupling.

DI singleton vs `object` singleton: a Hilt `@Singleton` is app-scoped, injectable, and fakeable in tests; a Kotlin `object` is a static global that's hard to test, can leak `Context`, and tempts hidden coupling. Always use DI for stateful global holders.

39.12 Security Considerations

- **Reset session-scoped global state on logout** (Ch 22/42) — session, profile, unread count, and any user-derived global state must clear so the next user/none doesn't see it (a global holder is a common leak point).

- **Don't put secrets in global holders** as plaintext — tokens live in Keystore- backed storage (Ch 20), not a `StateFlow<String>` everyone reads; expose only non-sensitive derived state (e.g., `isAuthenticated`).
- **Global flags aren't authorization** — a `FeatureFlags`/entitlement value is a client hint; the backend re-validates (Ch 41/26).
- **Device- vs session-scoped:** theme/flags are device-scoped (persist across users); session/profile are session-scoped (clear on logout). Scope correctly to avoid leaking user state into device state.
- Client vs backend: global state reflects the client's view; the backend remains authoritative for anything security-relevant (session validity, entitlements).

39.13 Performance and Resource Optimization

- **`StateFlow` is conflated + shared** — many observers, one value, minimal cost; `WhileSubscribed` stops idle upstream work.
- **Only truly-global state is global** — keeping UI/feature state out of global holders avoids memory bloat and unnecessary recomposition.
- **Combine lazily:** a feature `combine`s only the holders it needs, recomputing its `UiState` on relevant changes only.
- **Durable reads cached in memory** (`StateFlow` from DataStore) — no disk read per access.
- **Avoid a god object** that forces every feature to recompute on any global change.
- **Profiling:** recomposition driven by global-state changes, memory of holders, observer counts.

39.14 Testing Strategy

Focused holders are injectable → easy to fake; features test against fake global state.

```
class ShopViewModelGlobalStateTest {
    @Test fun `offline flag from connectivity shows banner`() = runTest {
        val vm = ShopViewModel(
            flags = FakeFlags(mapOf("new_search" to false)),
            connectivity = FakeConnectivity(NetworkState.Offline),
            session = FakeSession(SessionState.Unauthenticated),
            getProducts = FakeProducts(),
        )
        assertTrue(vm.uiState.first().offline)
    }
    @Test fun `logged-out hides account UI`() = runTest {
        val vm = shopVm(session = FakeSession(SessionState.Unauthenticated))
        assertFalse(vm.uiState.first().loggedIn)
    }
}

class ThemeRepositoryTest {
    @Test fun `theme persists and emits`() = runTest {
        val repo = ThemeRepository(tempDataStore(), bgScope)
        repo.setTheme(Theme.Dark)
        assertEquals(Theme.Dark, repo.theme.first { it == Theme.Dark })
    }
}
```

What to test: features against **fake holders** (not a real god object); holder behavior (connectivity callbacks, theme persistence); reset-on-logout clears session-scoped holders; no feature depends on more global state than it uses (review/ lint).

39.15 Production Observability

- **Metrics:** global-state change frequency (theme/flags/session/connectivity), recomposition driven by global changes, logout-reset completeness, divergence incidents (should be 0).
- **Logs:** `global{holder, change}` (types, no PII, Ch 28); session/connectivity transitions.
- **Debugging:** two features disagree on a global value → duplicated state (not one holder); global state lost on restart → not durable (Ch 4); hard to test/change a feature → god-object coupling; cross-user state after logout → session-scoped holder not reset.
- **Privacy:** session/profile global state is user data — redact; reset on logout.

39.16 System Design Interview Preparation

> ≥25 questions.

Fundamentals

1. *What is global state?* State read by many unrelated features, tied to app/session (session, connectivity, theme, flags, unread).
2. *Global vs feature vs screen state?* Many features vs one feature (Ch 38) vs one screen (Ch 6).
3. *How to expose global state?* A focused `@Singleton` holder with a read-only `StateFlow`.
4. *Why not a god object?* Couples every feature; untestable; single point of change.
5. *"Global" = static?* No — app-scoped via DI (`@Singleton`), injectable; not a Kotlin `object`.

Design

6. *Many holders vs central store?* Many focused holders (Android-idiomatic, modular); central store adds coupling/ceremony.
7. *How do features consume global state?* Inject only needed holders; `combine` into `UiState` (UDF).
8. *Who writes global state?* The owning holder (single writer); features call its methods.
9. *Durable global state?* Back with DataStore/Room (Ch 4/22); in-memory for recomputable.

Scoping/lifecycle

10. *Survives process death?* Durable holders (DataStore/Room); in-memory recomputes.
11. *Device- vs session-scoped?* Theme/flags (device) vs session/profile (session, clear on logout).
12. *Reset on logout?* Clear session-scoped global holders (Ch 22).

Consistency

13. *How avoid "is online" divergence?* One holder; all observe it.
14. *Multiple observers?* `StateFlow` shares one conflated value.
15. *Over-globalization risk?* Coupling; keep feature state in the feature (Ch 38).

Security

16. *Secrets in global holders?* No — Keystore (Ch 20); expose only non-sensitive derived state.
17. *Flags as authorization?* No — backend re-validates (Ch 41/26).
18. *Scope correctly?* Device vs session to avoid leaking user state.

Testing

19. *How test features with global state?* Fake holders; no real god object.
20. *How test holders?* Behavior (callbacks/persistence) + reset.

Performance

21. *Cost of global `StateFlow`?* Minimal (conflated/shared); `WhileSubscribed`.
22. *Memory?* Only global state is global — no UI bloat.

Production debugging

23. *Features disagree on a value?* Duplicated state, not one holder.
24. *Lost on restart?* Not durable.
25. *Hard to change a feature?* God-object coupling.
26. *Cross-user after logout?* Holder not reset.

Design-change challenges

1. **Five features track "is online" differently.** One `ConnectivityManager` holder.
2. **Theme must persist + apply app-wide.** DataStore-backed `ThemeRepository`.
3. **A god `GlobalStore` is unmaintainable.** Split into focused holders.
4. **Global state leaks across users.** Reset session-scoped holders on logout.
5. **Many global states in one screen.** `combine` only the needed holders.

Mock walkthrough (abridged)

Clarify (what state, who reads it, durable?) → classify global vs feature vs screen → focused `@Singleton` holder + `StateFlow` per global state (not a god object) → features inject + `combine` needed holders → durability (Ch 4/22) → reset on logout → device vs session scope → testing with fakes.

39.17 Practical Exercises

1. **Beginner.** Expose connectivity as a `@Singleton` holder with a `StateFlow`; observe it from two features. *Eval:* one source; both consistent.
2. **Intermediate.** Add a durable `ThemeRepository` (DataStore) applied app-wide; persists across restart. *Eval:* survives restart; app re-themes.
3. **Advanced.** Have a screen `combine` session + connectivity + flags into its `UiState`; inject only those holders. *Eval:* narrow deps; reactive.
4. **Production debugging.** Refactor a god `GlobalStore` into focused holders and fix a cross-user leak (no reset on logout). *Eval:* modular; cleared on logout.
5. **System design challenge.** Define the global/feature/screen boundary for an app and justify each; implement reset-on-logout for session-scoped holders. *Eval:* minimal global surface; correct scoping.

(Solutions withheld unless requested.)

39.18 Chapter Summary & Reference Sheet

Key decisions: expose each **genuinely-global** state (session, connectivity, theme, flags, unread — read by many unrelated features) through its **own focused, app-scoped (`@Singleton`) holder** with a read-only `StateFlow`, owned by one module and observed via **UDF** (`combine` only what a feature needs) — **never a god object** and **never more global than necessary**; back **durable** global state with DataStore/Room (Ch 4/22), recompute in-memory state on start; **reset session-scoped** global state on logout (Ch 22/42) while **device-scoped** (theme/flags) persists; use **DI singletons, not `object` singletons**; keep **secrets out** of global holders (Ch 20). Most state is **not** global.

Concepts: global vs feature vs screen state, focused holders vs god object, app-scoped DI singleton vs static, `StateFlow` exposure + UDF consumption, durable vs in-memory global state, device- vs session-scope, composition over central store.

Common mistakes: a god `GlobalStore` (coupling/untestable); over-globalizing feature state (Ch 38); duplicated global state (divergence); `object` singletons (leaks/untestable); global state lost on process death (no durability); secrets in global holders; not resetting session-scoped global state on logout.

Checklist:

- [ ] classify global/feature/screen
- [ ] focused `@Singleton` holder per global state
- [ ] read-only `StateFlow` + methods
- [ ] features combine only needed holders
- [ ] durable via DataStore/Room where needed
- [ ] in-memory recompute otherwise
- [ ] reset session-scoped on logout
- [ ] device vs session scope
- [ ] no god object
- [ ] no secrets in holders.

Key APIs/patterns: Hilt `@Singleton` holders, `StateFlow` / `stateIn` / `SharingStarted`, `combine`, `callbackFlow` (connectivity), DataStore-backed `StateFlow` (Ch 4), UDF (Ch 6), reset on logout (Ch 22).

References:

- Guide to app architecture (UI/state): https://developer.android.com/topic/architecture
- StateFlow/SharedFlow: https://developer.android.com/kotlin/flow/stateflow-and-sharedflow
- Hilt scopes (Ch 5): https://developer.android.com/training/dependency-injection/hilt-android#component-scopes
- (composes) Ch 22 Session, Ch 38 Shared Cart, Ch 40 Shared VM, Ch 41 Flags, Ch 68 Connectivity

Chapter review (Phase 4)

- **Completeness:** all 18 sections; architecture/class/sequence/failure diagrams; focused holders (connectivity/theme) + feature composition + anti-pattern + reset; concurrency (one conflated StateFlow); failure (god object, divergence, durability, leak); 5 levels; holders-vs-store and DI-vs-object trade-offs; security (reset/scope/secrets); perf (conflated, minimal global); fake-holder tests; observability (divergence); 26 Q&A + 5 challenges. ✅
- **Expand later:** shared VM scoping (Ch 40), flags/remote config (Ch 41), multi-account scoping (Ch 42), theme (Ch 97).
- **Interview coverage:** exceeds ≥25 bar.